Why Cities Are Planting Trees

Many cities are planting thousands of street trees to fight rising summer heat. Paved streets and roofs absorb sunlight and release it at night, which makes cities several degrees warmer than nearby countryside. This is called the urban heat island effect. Trees cool streets by shading pavement and by releasing water vapor from their leaves.

Studies in several US cities found that blocks with more tree cover were up to 10 degrees Fahrenheit cooler on hot afternoons. Trees also soak up stormwater, reduce noise, and are linked to lower stress for residents.

The programs have challenges. Young trees need watering for their first three years, and many die when that care stops. Some neighborhoods with the least shade also have the fewest resources to maintain new trees, so cities are starting to pay local groups to water and protect them.